WHAT IS THE WAY OUT?

Dharmendra Pradhan, the Union minister for education, has already talked about reforming the NTA. The Justice A.K. Rajan Committee, constituted by Tamil Nadu in 2021, had given some drastic suggestions. One recommendation was that the state use legal provisions to scrap NEET for medical entrance exams. Instead, it wants the higher secondary exam scores to become the sole admission criteria.

Many experts say India can learn from other countries like the US, which has standardised tests—SAT (Scholastic Assessment Test) and ACT (American College Test)—for college-bound students. Some 2 million students take these every year. "The US model is suitable for India as it offers flexibility and reduces the stress with multiple test dates throughout the year," says Prof. Ramgopal Rao, vice-chancellor of BITS Pilani. He adds that the NTA's transparency issues can be resolved if it is given constitutional status like the UPSC (Union Public Service Commission).

Other experts point to strengthening our medical education infrastructure so that exams aren't so competitive in the first place. There are currently 706 medical colleges in India, 386 of them government, offering 109,170 seats for MBBS, 15 per cent of the seats in government medical colleges are reserved for the All-India Quota, the rest for the home states. One suggestion is to increase the number of seats by converting district hospitals into medical colleges using the PPP model. Medical education can also be made more affordable, particularly in private colleges, to ease the competition for government college seats. The National Medical Commission (NMC) Act has the provision to regulate fees and all other charges in 50 per cent of the seats in private medical colleges and deemed universities and is framing guidelines in this regard. "Let us be honest, this country needs more doctors," says a professor of medicine at AIIMS Delhi, who did not wish to be named. "Most of us are massively overworked, seeing 30-35 patients a day, which is not good at all. We need to figure out a system to produce more doctors, and quality ones at that. We have seen a huge drop in the quality of students coming to study medicine. Most of them have just tired themselves out memorising useless things and either drop out within a year or perform poorly."

Last year, medical malpractice suits in India hit the 5.2 million cases mark with incidents rising by 110 per cent and litigation by 400 per cent. Experts say this also raises doubts on whether NEET is bringing the best minds to medicine.

Regarding malpractices, many say the exam should be shifted to online mode. "NEET should be conducted online. This will solve so many issues. The exam should also be conducted in two stages, like JEE and JEE Mains, so that students have the option to retake the test in six months and not wait a whole year," says Anil Nagar, founder of vernacular test prep platform, Adda247.

Others question the very quality of NEET, asserting that it has gone down over the years, becoming highly repetitive. Rao says entrance exams should have a large question bank with varying difficulty levels, randomly picked by an algorithm for each candidate. "This, along with real-time adaptation and immediate provision of raw scores after the test, could effectively address the challenges of scaling up exams," he says.



"WE'LL DO EVERYTHING TO ENSURE THAT THE SANCTITY OF THE INSTITUTION IS MAINTAINED. THE MATTER IS IN COURT AND WE ARE READY TO FACE ANY INQUIRY"

–PROF. PRADEEP KUMAR JOSHI
Chairman, National Testing Agency (NTA)



"THE QUESTION IS, WHAT IF THERE ARE OTHER DISCREPANCIES WE ARE UNAWARE OF? THE ISSUE OF PAPER LEAKS IS ALREADY OUT IN THE OPEN"

–ALAKH PANDEY, *CEO, PhysicsWallah*

Students also say that there is too much emphasis on rote learning. "I understand that Biology needs to be mugged up, but that shouldn't be the case with Physics and Chemistry. There should be application-based questions, not just theoretical," says Ankur Mukherjee, 19. Ankur got lucky in his second NEET attempt in 2023. With a score of 677 and an all-India rank of 1,847, he got into Vardhman Mahavir Medical College (VMMC) in the capital. When his first attempt in 2022 didn't go as planned—he scored 583—he decided to retake the test and took a gap year. Ashutosh Mehta, 18, from Mumbai hasn't been as lucky. He retook the exam this year and his rank has dropped by 60,000. "Last year, I could have got into a few public colleges, but they were not the best ones. This year, I can't get through any," he laments. He's given up on his dreams and is joining his father's export business.

While minister Pradhan has promised strong action against the NTA officials if guilty, it is of little consolation for the students. The stress of preparing for the exam was bad enough, having it cancelled or forced to take a retest could be the end of the dream altogether. ■

with Shelly Anand, Jumana Shah, Amitabh Srivastava and Rahul Noronha